been revealed to, or heard by, the *rishi*s, codified by Veda Vyasa and passed down through generations of disciples. But they are not revealed texts in the Christian or Muslim senses of the term; the *rishi* is a Mantra-Drashta, a seer of mantra or thought; the thought is not his own, but he 'hears' or 'sees' it. It is interesting that the Sanksrit word for philosophy is *darshana*, literally 'seeing': the perception of the seer is as important in Hinduism as his intellectual enquiry. In this, too, Hindu philosophy differs considerably from its Western counterparts.

In fact the *Rig Veda* is estimated to have taken perhaps half a millennium to attain its corpus of 10,552 mantras in verse, and in the course of these five centuries at least fifty poet-*rishi*s had a hand in its composition. Their sacredness comes from their divine inspiration and sustained quality, not from having been handed down fully composed by God like the Quran. The story is no different with the later Vedas; the four Vedas are believed to have been created between 1500 BCE and 500 BCE, a period of one thousand years. In that period we see enormous evolution from the nomadic faith of the *Rig Veda*, in which animal sacrifices, including those of cattle, were offered to the gods[11] and the healthy scepticism in some of its verses, to the evidence in the later Vedas of adjustment to new social realities, such as the *Yajur Veda*'s references to new gods, clearly taken into Hinduism from prevailing local faiths—including Pashupati, Lord of the Beasts, and Aushadi, Lord of Medicinal Herbs.

Similarly the 108 *Upanishad*s, which distil the essence of the Vedic philosophy, are also Sruti (revealed literature). They were also written over centuries: it is believed that the first eight go back to the period between the eighth century BCE to the fourth century BCE, congruent with the Age of the Buddha. The next three *Upanishad*s are post-Buddhist and date from 300 BCE to 200 CE, whereas the remaining 97 *Upanishad*s belong to the Puranic period—from the second century CE to the tenth century CE. The chronological gap between the earliest verses of the Rig Veda and the bulk of the *Upanishad*s was greater than the time that separates us today from the life of Jesus Christ. An entire *Upanishad* (the *Mandukya Upanishad*) is devoted to the primal sound, Om. In the reckoning of many Hindus, the Upa-Vedas, or subsidiary